Case Study:

UPI/Online Payment Fraud

UPI/Online Payment Fraud is one of the most common cybercrimes in India, where attackers trick users into transferring money through digital payment platforms. This type of fraud usually targets students, elderly individuals, and people unfamiliar with digital payment security.

A typical scenario begins when the fraudster contacts the victim via phone call, SMS, or social media, pretending to be a bank official, customer care executive, or even a buyer/seller. The attacker then creates urgency, such as claiming there is an issue with the victim's bank account or offering a fake reward or refund. Next, the victim is asked to share sensitive information like OTPs or is tricked into approving a "collect request" on a UPI app. In some cases, the victim is asked to install screen-sharing apps, allowing the fraudster to access their device. Once the victim unknowingly authorizes the transaction, money is instantly transferred to the attacker's account.

The consequences can be severe, including financial loss, emotional stress, and loss of trust in digital systems. Since UPI transactions are instant, recovering the money becomes extremely difficult.

This situation can be prevented by never sharing OTPs, carefully reading payment requests, avoiding unknown links or apps, and verifying the identity of the requester before making any transaction.